Upholding the rights of all Serbian voters

Challenges met by diaspora citizens ahead of the 25 October election – and how to address them

An assessment prepared by the Student Movement of Serbia

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Executive summary

The Republic of Serbia counts around 6.5 million inhabitants, but it also has a significantly large proportion of its citizens outside its borders, usually referred to as the “diaspora”: depending on the estimates, the Serbian diaspora could represent between 2.5 and 5 million people.

Citizens in the diaspora have the same voting rights as those living on the territory of the Republic of Serbia. Information from the ground accessed by the Student Movement through its network of observers suggests an unprecedented level of civic engagement from diaspora citizens.

While the highest number of polling stations abroad has been 81 in the last 20 years, enough citizens are registering to open at least 129 polling stations for the 25 October elections – a 59% increase. These locations would cover at least 49 countries, and more than 50 of these stations would be new locations.

Ten systemic obstacles for diaspora citizens to exercise their voting rights

However, the Student Movement is receiving multiple complaints from diaspora citizens, on what are critical dysfunctions impeding the exercise of their voting rights. These complaints can be summarized in the form of 10 systemic obstacles:

1. **Unresponsive diplomatic missions:** Embassies or consulates do not confirm receipt and do not respond to emails and calls, in some cases for more than 7 days, and sometimes for weeks.

2. **Unprocessed requests:** Hundreds of requests remain unprocessed. The oldest confirmed example is Abu Dhabi, where requests from voters to register dating from 13 September are still not processed.

3. **Refusal to open polling stations:** With the excuse of "lacking capacity", diplomatic missions refuse to open polling stations, while not having the authority to decide. It is the RIK, not the diplomatic missions, who decides on polling stations.

4. **Conditions that are not in the law:** Cases where diplomatic missions do not follow the law are being reported. For instance, voter registration based on the residence of parents is refused, although Article 6 of the Law on the Unified Voter List allows it.

5. **Incorrect information about the procedure:** Voters receive a notification that their registration request has been “forwarded to the RIK”, but by law the requests must go to the given municipality where they are supposed to be processed, not to the RIK.

6. **Contradictory notices about the polling place:** Citizens receive contradictory and changing notices about where the polling place will be in their country of residence, sometimes receiving the news that the station will be in a distant city, or, worse, in another country.

7. **Pressure to change polling stations, through phone calls:** Citizens report receiving phone calls from diplomatic missions asking them to register to other polling stations altogether, without clear explanations on the reasons why.

8. **Shifting responsibility:** Voters referred back and forth between diplomatic missions and municipal administrations.

9. **Undelivered municipal decisions:** Voters simply do not receive confirmation or decisions regarding their registration status.

10. **Delayed or missing calls for registration:** Diplomatic missions publishing calls for registration with significant delay or not at all.

Five key things that must happen to enable the vote of Serbian diaspora citizens and uphold their rights

- **Every registration request submitted by 3 October, 23:59:59 (Serbian time) must be processed.** Each voter receives a confirmation of receipt, and the request is forwarded to the concerned municipality (Art. 16 of the Law on the Unified Voter List); the municipality's decision on the request may follow after 3 October. An unprocessed request means denying the citizen's right to vote.
- **Polling stations are available in all 129 locations where the threshold is met.** Where fewer than 100 voters are registered, the RIK applies an exception allowed by law, as is done on the territory of the Republic of Serbia. In 2023, there were 492 polling stations in the country with less than 100 voters.
- **No excuses of "lack of capacity" or invented conditions:** Only the law applies. Enrollment through parent residence is valid (Art. 6 of the Law on the Unified Voter List), and RIK decides on polling stations (Art. 56 of the Law on the Election of People's Deputies).

- **Full transparency on the process:** The Ministry of Foreign Affairs and RIK publish data for each diplomatic mission: how many requests were received, forwarded, approved, rejected, and how many are pending.

- **Public accountability and tracking:** All violations are documented, monitored, and reported to the public.

Who needs to do what in the coming weeks

Timeline / Deadline	Required Action / Responsibility
By 3 October (application deadline)	Ministry of Foreign Affairs and diplomatic missions shall: ● Provide, without delay, confirmation of receipt for each voter registration request, and forward it to the concerned municipality promptly after it is submitted — including requests submitted up to 3 October, 23:59:59 (Serbian time), whose forwarding and processing may extend beyond that date ● Publicly provide written correction of incorrect instructions; ● Urgently publish a call for voter registration where there still has been none.
By 4 October, 23:59:59 (Serbian time)	The RIK shall have: ● Decided on opening polling stations in all locations where the threshold is met, and where exceptions are made for locations where the number of registered voters is below 100; ● Issued a public list of polling stations with the number of registered voters per station.
Until the election	● Decisions received from the competent municipal administration are forwarded to the concerned voter without delay, and invitations to vote reach each voter on time (Art. 86 of the Law on Election of People's Deputies); ● Publication of addresses and working hours of polling stations are published timely; ● Access to observers, including OSCE/ODIHR, is granted.
On election day, 25 October	● Every voter who has received confirmation can vote at the indicated place;

	● No voter is denied voting due to a mistake by the diplomatic mission or the processing municipality.
After the election	● Results and turnout are published for each polling station abroad; ● Data on all rejected and unprocessed requests is publicly available; ● Independent investigations of reported violations take place.

Deadlines, process, and legal grounding of diaspora voters' rights

How it works:

- A polling station abroad may be opened where a minimum of 100 and a maximum of 2,500 voters register, subject to the RIK's assessment of possibility under Art. 57 of the Law on the Election of People's Deputies. An exception is possible with the approval of the Republic Electoral Commission (Republička izborna komisija, or RIK), if the nearest polling station is too far or for other justified reasons.

- Diplomatic missions (*diplomatski-konzularno predstavništva*) receive the requests to open polling stations and forward them to a municipality or city in Serbia, and the municipal administration then decides on the request (Law on the Unified Voter List, Art. 16).

- A voter can also register according to the last place of residence of one parent. (Law on the Unified Voter List, Art. 6).

- The invitation to vote is delivered to the voter by the diplomatic mission (Law on Election of People's Deputies, Art. 86).

- Voting abroad lasts 13 hours and ends no later than 20:00 Serbian time (Law on Election of People's Deputies, Art. 91).

- The president of the electoral committee abroad is an employee of the diplomatic mission. The members of the extended composition are proposed by electoral lists (Law on Election of People's Deputies, Art. 38 and 39).

Key deadlines:

- 3 October: The deadline for registering to vote abroad is 3 October, 23:59:59 (Serbian time).
- 4 October, 23:59:59 (Serbian time): The RIK designates polling stations abroad at the proposal of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, no later than 20 days before the election, *i.e.*, by 4 October, 23:59:59 (Serbian time) (Law on Election of People's Deputies, Art. 56, Paragraph 2).
- 9 October: The unified voter list is consolidated and closed on 9 October.

Introduction

Citizens in the diaspora have the same voting rights as those living on the territory of the Republic of Serbia (see the section on deadlines, process and legal grounding for a brief explainer). Yet, the turnout of diaspora voters has been, in proportion to the number of citizens living outside the country, historically low. This is partly explained by the usually low number of polling stations abroad.

Ahead of the 25 October elections, our network of observers across the world reports what resembles an unprecedented mobilisation of voters in the diaspora. The Student Movement monitors the number of reported citizens' registrations, and the latest numbers indicate that the threshold to establish polling stations has been crossed for 129 locations across 49 countries.

This, in itself, is – or should be – the object of collective civic pride. Indeed, 129 polling stations represent 59% more locations than in 2023 (the last parliamentary elections), when voting abroad was possible at 81 polling stations. Furthermore, of the 129 locations, more than 50 are new ones that were not open in 2023.

This remarkable increase in civic engagement, however, is facing a series of systemic obstacles. As was publicly reported in the media by several sources[1], and including alerts

[1] See for example:
021.rs (24 September 2026): Da li država Srbija opstruiše glasanje u dijaspori: Zašto se ne otvaraju nova biračka mesta?
Srpske Novine (25 September 2026): Serbia Diaspora Voting Deadline: RIK Missing Embassy Data N1 (25 September 2026): Izazovi glasanja u dijaspori

launched by our movement[2], citizens abroad are reporting multiple difficulties to exercise their rights ahead of the 25 October election, from not being able to register to not knowing where to actually vote.

As key deadlines are approaching to close the lists of diaspora voters and polling stations, all efforts must be spent to guarantee that Serbian citizens abroad can exercise their rights. The network of embassies has a central role to play here, yet multiple reports from all continents suggest that embassies are actively preventing diaspora voters from inserting their ballot indeed.

This report aims at providing an assessment of the situation, based on what was directly reported by citizens worldwide to the Student Movement, and to making key recommendations on how to urgently address the situation.

The report is organized as follows:

- **Section 1** first presents historic data on diaspora vote since 2007, covering the number of registered voters, the voter turnout, and the number of polling stations for each election cycle. It then gives the list of all 129 locations where people on the ground have reported to us that they have applied for a polling station, with a breakdown of cities by country.
- **Section 2** then provides an overview of the 10 systemic problems posed by Serbian embassies, as identified by the Student Movement based on what people on the ground have reported. The section also provides concrete examples of observed behaviors from embassies, ranging from simply closing off communication to being inconsistent about polling station locations.

- **Section 3** concludes by proposing a breakdown of what should be done in the coming weeks, at the level of diplomatic missions (*e.g.*, embassies/consulates), the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and the Republic Electoral Commission (*Republička izborna komisija*, or RIK) in Belgrade, to uphold the law and diaspora citizens' voting rights. It then describes how the Student Movement will follow the election abroad and ensure that, if and where voters' rights are violated, responsible individuals are legally held accountable.

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[2] nova.rs (26 September 2026): Studenti zahtevaju hitnu reakciju MSP-a i RIK-a, tvrde da se ignorišu zahtevi građana za glasanje u inostranstvu: Objavili spisak najalarmantnijih slučajeva po državama

1. The diaspora is witnessing a surge in civic engagement: 129 polling stations have been requested in 49 countries

As mentioned in the introduction, the Student Movement is directly in contact with diaspora citizens on the ground and is constantly monitoring the mobilization for the 25 October election.

Independently from political affiliation or preference, the signals we have been receiving suggest an exceptionally strong participation of the diaspora in the next elections, compared to previous elections cycles in the last 20 years.

We have registered no less than 129 locations where the threshold of 100 registered citizens has been met, which should by law automatically lead to the establishment of a polling station (see the section on deadlines, process and legal grounding).These locations are spread across 49 countries in Europe, the Americas, Africa, and Asia. This would represent a 59% increase compared to 2023.

1.1. Overview of passed election cycles: civic engagement in 2026 is off the charts

While the total number of individual voter registrations is not yet known (but see section 2), the number of voters usually follows the number of polling stations (see Table 1, Table 2 and Figure 1). .

Table 1. Registered voters, turnout, and number of polling stations outside Serbia (2007-2023), based on data from the Statistical Office of the Republic of Serbia.

Passed elections	Registered diaspora voters	Turnout	Polling stations outside Serbia
2007	31334	9871	81
2008	51211	18738	75
2012	6014	4256	38
2014	6808	4826	35
2016	8471	6084	37
2020	13251	9168	40
2022	39777	30141	77
2023	39270	31552	81

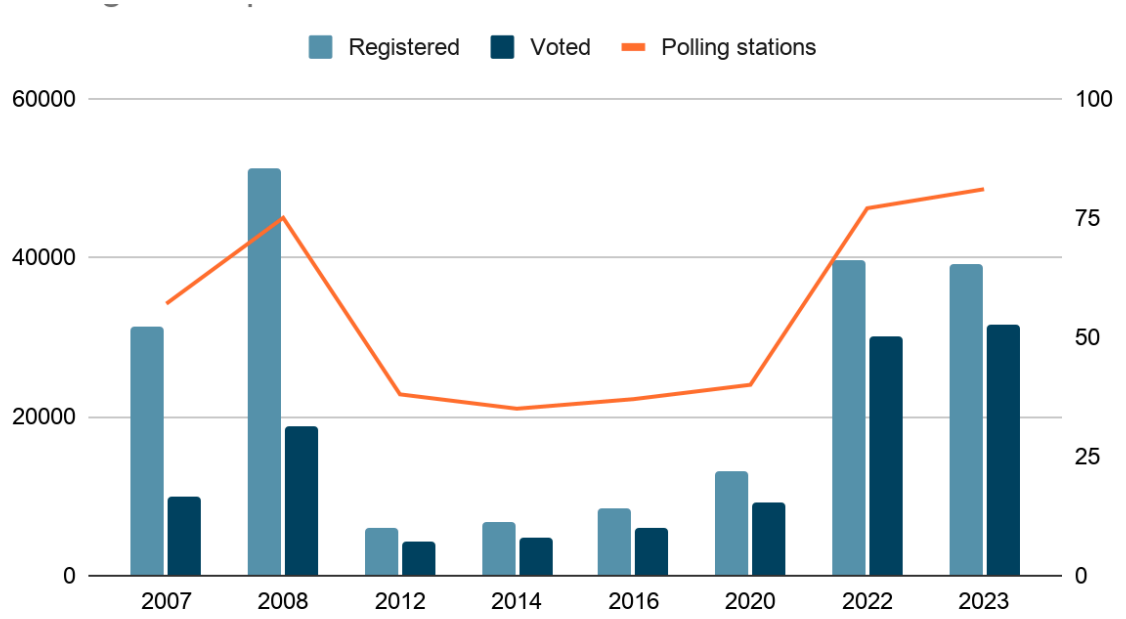


Figure 1. Registered voters, turnout, and number of polling stations outside Serbia (2007-2023), based on data from the Statistical Office of the Republic of Serbia.

Since 2007, the maximum number of polling stations has been 81 (in 2007 and in 2023). With 129 polling stations, this year's engagement, if enabled to be expressed, would literally put 2026 off the charts when it comes to civic engagement in the diaspora.

1.2. Where voters are asking for polling stations

Our information from the ground suggests that out of the 129 applications, more than 50 concern locations where no polling station was open in 2023. As can be seen in Table 2, Table 3 and Figure 2, the applications concern all continents, showing an engaged diaspora across different political cultures, geopolitical blocks, and development status of their country of residence.

It is important to note that this only covers locations where we know that enough people have registered for the RIK to establish a polling station. We know that citizens have also registered in other places, for instance in India or Latvia.

This signals a genuine increase in interest from diaspora citizens for the political affairs of their country of origin, which any political actor in Serbia should rejoice over.

Table 2. The 129 locations where the threshold of 100 registered voters has been passed, or where the nearest alternative polling station is too far to be a realistic option, which should lead to the establishment of a polling station. Based on information transmitted by citizens to the Student Movement.

Country	City	Total
Australia	Brisbane, Melbourne, Perth, Sydney	4
Austria	Vienna, Graz, Innsbruck, Linz, Salzburg	5
Bahrain	Manama	1
Belgium	Brussels	1
Bosnia and Herzegovina	Banja Luka, Bijeljina, Branjevo, Bratunac, Doboj, Drvar, Goražde, Lopare, Mostar, Mrkonjić Grad, Pale, Prijedor, Rudo, Sarajevo, Trebinje, Višegrad, Zvornik	17
Brazil	São Paulo	1
Bulgaria	Sofia	1
Canada	Ottawa, Toronto, Vancouver, Calgary	4
China	Beijing, Shanghai	2
Croatia	Rijeka, Split, Vukovar, Zagreb	4
Cuba	Havana	1
Cyprus	Nicosia	1
Czech Republic	Prague	1
Denmark	Copenhagen	1
Finland	Helsinki	1
France	Lyon, Nice, Paris, Strasbourg, Toulouse	5
Germany	Berlin, Düsseldorf, Frankfurt, Hamburg, Hannover, Karlsruhe, Cologne, Munich, Nuremberg, Stuttgart	10
Greece	Athens, Thessaloniki	2
Hungary	Budapest	1
Iceland	Reykjavik	1
Indonesia	Jakarta	1

Ireland	Dublin	1
Italy	Florence, Milan, Rome, Trieste, Vicenza	5
Japan	Tokyo	1
Kenya	Nairobi	1
Kuwait	Kuwait City	1
Lebanon	Beirut	1
Luxembourg	Luxembourg	1
Malta	St. Paul's Bay, Valletta	2
Montenegro	Berane, Herceg Novi, Podgorica, Sutomore	4
Netherlands	The Hague	1
New Zealand	Hamilton, Auckland	2
North Macedonia	Kumanovo, Skopje	2
Norway	Bergen, Oslo, Stavanger, Trondheim	4
Poland	Warsaw	1
Portugal	Lisbon	1
Qatar	Doha	1
Romania	Bucharest, Timişoara	2
Russia	Moscow	1
Slovakia	Bratislava	1
Slovenia	Koper, Ljubljana, Maribor	3
South Africa	Johannesburg	1
Spain	Barcelona, Madrid, Valencia	3
Switzerland	Basel, Bern, Zürich, Lugano, Geneva	5
Sweden	Gothenburg, Malmö, Stockholm	3
Türkiye	Ankara, Istanbul	2
United Arab Emirates	Abu Dhabi, Dubai	2
United Kingdom	Birmingham, Edinburgh, London, Manchester	4

United States	Chicago, Houston, Los Angeles, Miami, New York, San Diego, San Francisco, Washington	8

Regardless of whether the 100-voter threshold has been met, the Student Movement draws particular attention to locations where the nearest alternative polling station is in another city or country, often thousands of kilometers away — including Manama (Bahrain), Havana (Cuba), Nairobi (Kenya), Beirut (Lebanon), Hamilton (New Zealand), and Santiago (Chile). For these voters, the absence of a local polling station is not a minor inconvenience but a practical barrier to voting at all. The RIK retains the authority to open a polling station where the nearest one is too far, or for other justified reasons (Art. 57 of the Law on the Election of People's Deputies — see the section on deadlines, process and legal grounding). The Student Movement recommends that RIK give particular consideration to these locations when finalizing the list of polling stations.

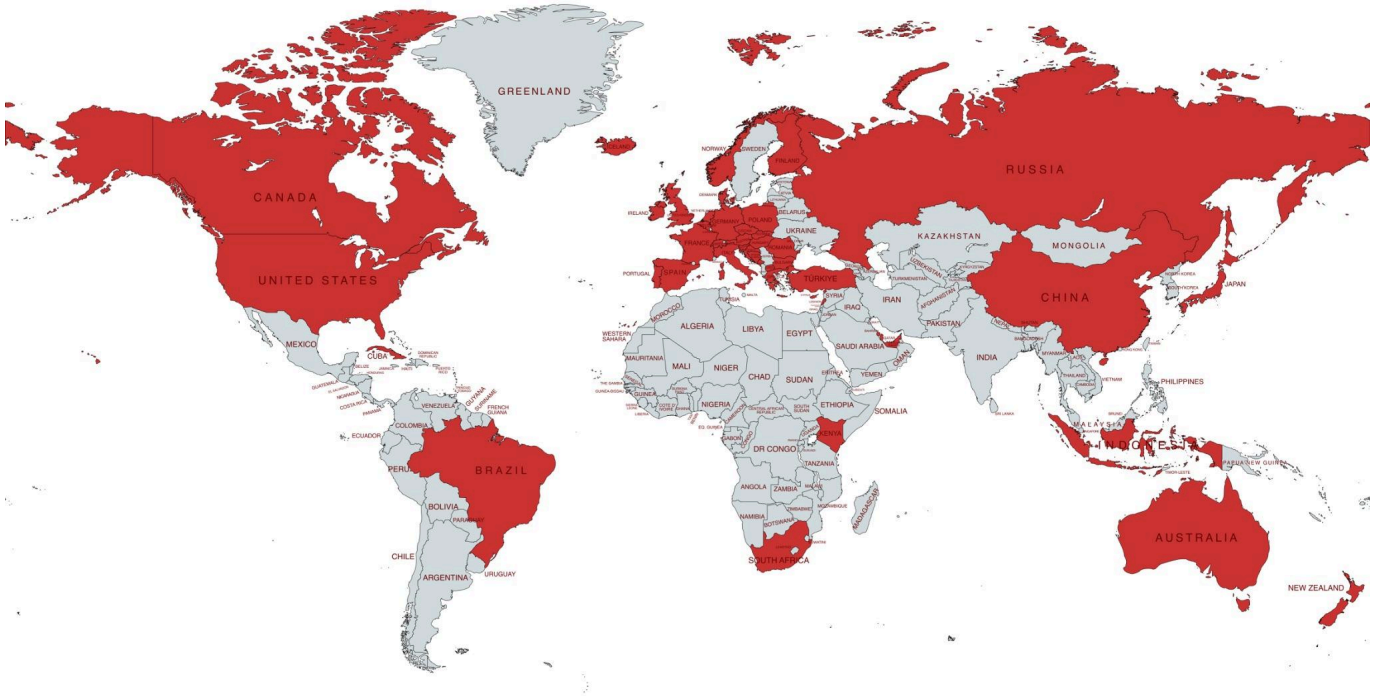


Figure 2. The 49 countries where the locations for the potential 129 polling stations should be based. More locations could be decided if the RIK decides to establish polling stations where less than 100 voters have registered. Based on information transmitted by citizens to the Student Movement.

2. Observed systemic problems

This section is based on reports submitted directly to the Student Movement by diaspora citizens, primarily through the official email, a dedicated form, and social media, between 10 September and 28 September 2026. Each report was logged by the Student Movement's network of observers, noting the country and city of the voter, the date of contact with the diplomatic mission, and the response received, if any. The figures below reflect only the reports recorded by the Student Movement and should be treated as a floor, not a ceiling.

As summarized in the Executive Summary, these reports reveal a pattern of 10 recurring systemic obstacles faced by diaspora voters worldwide. To provide a clearer picture of the issues on the ground, the subsection below highlights concrete, verified examples collected across 18 countries.

2.1. Illustrative examples from 18 countries

Country	City	Problem
Austria	Vienna	No confirmation of receipt of emails and requests
Belgium	Brussels	No response even after reminders
Bosnia and Herzegovina	Banja Luka	No response even after reminders
China	Beijing, Shanghai	Voters from Guangdong and Hong Kong redirected to Beijing. Beijing confirmed that voters can choose the city and forwarded the requests, but Shanghai does not respond and says that the requests have been "forwarded to the RIK". Municipalities return voters to the consulate. There are no voter confirmations in Beijing, even though the municipalities have sent them
Cuba/Dominican Republic	Havana	The embassy has not published a call for applications
Czech Republic	Brno (Honorary Consul)	They make the excuse that there is “no capacity” and refer voters to Prague
France	Paris	No response even after reminders
Germany	Berlin, Stuttgart, Frankfurt	Hundreds of requests unprocessed for more than 7 days, no answers to calls and emails

Germany	Hamburg / Hannover	Voter confirmation for Hanover and then an email to vote in Hamburg
Indonesia	Jakarta	There is no response to emails
Ireland	(through London)	No response even after reminders
Italy	Rome	Repeated requests are not answered and decisions of the municipalities are not submitted
Italy	Milano	Telephone pressure on voters to change city (Bologna or Milan), with the claim that Florence "is not in the jurisdiction"
Montenegro	Herceg Novi	No response even after reminders
Romania	Bucharest	No response even after reminders
Singapore	Singapore	Voters informed that the polling station will not be open and directed to Jakarta
Slovenia	Ljubljana	No response even after reminders
Slovenia	Koper	They make the excuse that there is 'no capacity', as this is a newly opened consulate, and have stated that voting will not be organized there — the same situation as in Brno (Czech Republic).
Switzerland	Bern, Zurich	No response even after reminders
United Kingdom	London	No answer for weeks. The staff claims that it is not possible to enroll through the residence of the parents (contrary to Art. 6 of the Law on the Unified Voter List)
United Arab Emirates	Abu Dhabi	Requests from 13 September still unprocessed

3. Recommendations to enable the vote of Serbian diaspora citizens and uphold their rights

1. Every registration request submitted by 3 October, 23:59:59 (Serbian time) must be processed. Each voter receives a confirmation of receipt, and the request is forwarded to the concerned municipality (Art. 16 of the Law on the Unified Voter List); the municipality's decision on the request may follow after 3 October. An unprocessed request means denying the citizen's right to vote.

2. Polling stations are available in all 129 locations where the threshold is met, as well as in locations where the nearest alternative is too far to be a realistic option. Where fewer than 100 voters are registered, the RIK applies an exception allowed by law, as is done on the territory of the Republic of Serbia. In 2023, there were 492 polling stations in the country with less than 100 voters.

3. There shall not be excuses of “lack of capacity” or invented conditions. Only the law applies. Enrollment through the residence of the parents is allowed (Art. 6 of the Law on the Unified Voter List), and the RIK decides on polling stations (Art. 56 of the Law on the Election of People's Deputies) – this is not the responsibility of the diplomatic missions or Honorary Consuls.

4. Full transparency on the process: The Ministry of Foreign Affairs and RIK publish data for each diplomatic mission: how many requests were received, forwarded, approved, rejected, and how many are pending.

5. Public accountability and legal compliance: All violations are documented, monitored, and reported directly to the public, as well as to the competent law enforcement and judicial authorities.